

Chapter 45-1: Solitude

Ning Fuyi hurriedly looked at her own body, and all that met her eyes was glossy fur. She opened her mouth but no sound came out. When she held her hand up in front of herself, she saw a claw with sharp nails and paws completely covered in fur.

Looking at herself this way, she couldn't tell what she had become. So she hopped over to the bronze pillar in the great hall that was so polished it could reflect images, and discovered that she had actually become a golden hamster with bulging cheeks and a huge tail on her rear.

She wanted to let out an exclamation, but only squeaked.

"Judge, what is the meaning of this? My sect's disciples cannot be randomly transformed into beasts!" Elder Pingyao said angrily.

"Elder Pingyao." Mei Chengsi suddenly spoke to dissuade him, "Calm your anger."

Elder Pingyao looked at him, his thin lips pressed into a line, and said nothing more.

"Please don't be upset, Elder. I truly have no other solution. You don't know how chaotic the underworld has become. The number of people dying everywhere has suddenly increased, and every day they queue in front of the Bridge of Helplessness¹, so crowded it's completely blocked." Even though the judge's face was bloody and terrifying, one could still see a bitter expression on it.

"Besides that, there seems to be something wrong with the Meng Po Soup². Those who drink it not only fail to forget their previous lives, but become even more insane. Every day they block the entrance to the Reincarnation Well, unable to enter reincarnation. This causes many pregnant women in the mortal world to be unable to give birth, suffering extreme pain. The six realms are interconnected - if this continues for long, I fear there will be great chaos throughout the world." The judge clapped his hands as he spoke.

"The underworld already lacks ghost officers, and we can't even catch all the wandering spirits. The Yama Kings³ are also at their wit's end, which is why I dare to come here."

"Is this true?" Elder Pingyao frowned.

Elder Yuanming beside them nodded, unusually serious in his reply: "This is indeed not false. Recently many disciples traveling outside the sect have sent back messages mentioning many pregnant women unable to give birth."

Elder Pingyao stood with hands behind his back, deep in thought. Elder Jingshan was puzzled: "What has been happening these past days? After the incident at Zhaoyao Mountain⁴, the six sects dug three feet into the ground but couldn't find any trace of the demon clan. Even the Penglai Realm sent people to investigate, equally at a loss. That matter hasn't been resolved yet, and now the mortal world and underworld are becoming unstable again."

After the several people exchanged glances, they said nothing more, only looking toward Ning Fuyi.

"Ning Fuyi, are you willing to make this trip with Divine Venerable Chu Ling?" Elder Pingyao sighed.

Since they had already acted first and transformed her into a squirrel, what could she possibly say? Ning Fuyi was depressed and squeaked twice, but then thought that demons and ghosts were related - if she went to that gloomy underworld full of yin energy everywhere, she might find some opportunities.

So she nodded her head.

Seeing her agreement, the judge happily stretched his tongue out even longer, shaking the hat on his head: "On behalf of the underworld, I kowtow in gratitude to all of you."

"At the hour of zi⁵ tonight, I will come here again. When the gates of the underworld open wide, I will respectfully welcome you both." As he spoke, his voice gradually became unclear, and his body passed through the wall and left.

After he left, the night-shining pearls on the walls suddenly brightened, and the cold, sinister air was replaced by warm air. Ning Fuyi's body made a *pop* sound and changed back to its original form.

She spat out a few golden hamster hairs from her mouth twice before feeling more comfortable.

Chu Qingqiu, who had been silent all along, was now looking at her. Just when Ning Fuyi thought she would speak to stop this, the other person turned and left the great hall.

Instead, Elder Pingyao walked to her side and gave instructions: "Your cultivation is low, and the underworld is a place isolated from the outside world. Even we have never set foot there. You must stay close to Divine Venerable Chu Ling and help conceal her yang energy⁶ - that's enough. You needn't worry about other matters."

"Do you understand?" she said sternly.

"Yes." Ning Fuyi replied.

"Alright, go prepare. You don't need to attend today's lessons." Elder Pingyao said. When Ning Fuyi was taking her leave, she glanced around the great hall. Mei Chengsi's eyes hidden beneath his thick eyebrows were staring at her, while Elder Yuanming beside him coughed lightly, waving his fan and winking at her.

Ning Fuyi left.

The matter of her going to the underworld with Chu Qingqiu was not told to other disciples, only to Liu Wenzhu and Rong Jin. One was worried and the other excited, and they surrounded her all day.

"Throughout history, few living people have been able to enter the underworld. Now you can actually go with Divine Venerable Chu Ling - you'll surely have many strange encounters!" Liu Wenzhu said enviously while holding her thousand-jin hammer⁷. "If only I could follow along too. Then helping the underworld escape its troubles would reach my father's ears, and he would surely praise me."

"Though that may be so, the underworld is after all an untrodden place with many treacherous things. You must be very careful and stay close to Divine Venerable Chu Ling." Rong Jin was full of worry, giving repeated reminders.

Ning Fuyi was lectured by them all day about various records of the underworld. It wasn't until dusk that she escaped, and after bidding farewell to Ping An, she came to the front of Cloud Deep Hall.

Chu Qingqiu was already waiting there. Qiu Yi beside her held the white bone in her hands, her face full of worry: "Master, are you truly not allowing this disciple to follow? Your body has just recovered, and the underworld's yin energy is heavy, full of lonely souls and evil spirits..."

"Would I be afraid of ghosts?" Chu Qingqiu said softly, her fingertips as white as jade touching Qiu Yi's forehead and pushing her away, taking the white bone from her palm in passing.

Chu Qingqiu had never been so gentle with herself. Ning Fuyi's brow furrowed tightly, and she looked away.

She had known since her previous life that Chu Qingqiu loved and indulged that disciple of hers. She herself had no relationship with her whatsoever, so what was there to be dissatisfied about now? Ning Fuyi thought to herself.

"Why is it that she gets to follow Master..."

Qiu Yi's words came again. Ning Fuyi said irritably: "Because I was born at the zi hour of the Ghost Festival⁸. If you're capable, go change your birth time and eight characters⁹ too."

Qiu Yi's face turned red with anger, raising her hand to argue with her, but was stopped by Chu Qingqiu's gaze and aggrievedly began hitting her skirt corner.

"So many people are seeing me off?" At this moment, a clear and melodious voice sounded from behind. Jiang Li, carrying a medicine box, somehow came riding on auspicious clouds, gracefully landing with words like flowing pearls: "I thought I could leave without saying goodbye."

Chu Qingqiu looked slightly surprised: "Medical Immortal, won't you stay a few more days?"

"I came this time to treat Divine Venerable's injuries. Since Divine Venerable's injuries have healed, I need not stay. I've been traveling the four seas and eight wastelands¹⁰ treating people for years - it's been a hundred years since I've returned to Wu Mountain¹¹, so I'm eager to go back and see."

When passing by Ning Fuyi, she suddenly pulled Ning Fuyi aside, saying to Chu Qingqiu: "Let me borrow your disciple for a moment."

With that, she pulled Ning Fuyi to one side, her sleeve brushing across Ning Fuyi's palm, leaving behind a needle as thin as hair.

"What is this?" Ning Fuyi didn't understand.

"This is a bone-shaving needle, unique to the Jiang clan of Wu Mountain, made from the bones of deceased members of the Jiang clan." Jiang Li put away her smile and said seriously, "Though Divine Venerable's injury has healed, it will still recur. When it recurs, it will be like hundreds of bronze nails piercing through bone, a fate worse than death. When it recurs, pierce this needle into her heart to suppress it."

Though her words were calm, they struck Ning Fuyi's ears like thunder. She couldn't help but look toward Chu Qingqiu standing alone in the wind with her thin back.

How intense must the pain of bronze nails piercing bone be? Had she already experienced this? Or had she not?

"Divine Venerable forbade me to tell others, but there are no other cultivators in the underworld. Only you will be by her side, so I can only reveal a little, hoping you can help her when she's in extreme pain." Jiang Li spoke sincerely.

Only at this moment could Ning Fuyi see traces of a physician in her. So she put away the bone-shaving needle and said she understood.

"I was also acquainted with your mother. Though we only met a few times, each meeting was unforgettable." Jiang Li smiled, her eyes falling into memory, and patted Ning Fuyi on the shoulder.

Ning Fuyi was startled and was about to ask more, but Jiang Li pushed her away, loudly bidding farewell to Chu Qingqiu. Her graceful figure rose up, her silk scarf blending with the sunset's afterglow.

In the blink of an eye, she vanished at the horizon.

Just as she left, the judge appeared. The sky that had just been tinged with orange light suddenly darkened, like the sky before a storm. Strong winds rose all around, and leaves rustled.

Qiu Yi, who was seeing them off, was blown backward by the wind repeatedly. The judge appeared in mid-air with his tongue hanging out, swaying left and right like a hanged lonely soul, frightening Qiu Yi into continuous screams.

The judge seemed very satisfied with having scared someone, letting out a *ka ka ka ka* laugh, then threw down a red skull. On the originally empty white jade platform, a crimson bronze door suddenly appeared.

Footnotes:

¹ **Bridge of Helplessness (奈何桥):** A legendary bridge in Chinese mythology that souls must cross in the afterlife before reincarnation

- ² **Meng Po Soup (孟婆汤):** In Chinese mythology, a soup given to souls before reincarnation to make them forget their past lives
- ³ **Yama Kings (阎王):** Kings of the underworld in Chinese mythology who judge the dead
- ⁴ **Zhaoyao Mountain (招摇山):** A location mentioned in the story, likely the site of a previous incident
- ⁵ **Hour of zi (子时):** The first of the twelve traditional Chinese hours, corresponding to 11 PM to 1 AM
- ⁶ **Yang energy (阳气):** In Chinese philosophy, the active, masculine, positive energy that complements yin
- ⁷ **Thousand-jin hammer (千斤锤):** A very heavy weapon (jin is a traditional Chinese unit of weight)
- ⁸ **Ghost Festival (中元节):** Also known as the Hungry Ghost Festival, when the boundary between the living and dead is thinnest
- ⁹ **Eight characters (八字):** Refers to the eight characters used in Chinese astrology based on birth time, used for fortune-telling
- ¹⁰ **Four seas and eight wastelands (四海八荒):** A poetic way to refer to the entire world
- ¹¹ **Wu Mountain (巫山):** A mountain in Chinese mythology associated with shamanism and magic